DAAT TEVUNOT: THE RAMHAL ON CREATION, GOOD AND EVIL, AND THE SOUL

Can We Ever Speak About God Himself?

Daat Tevunot §45-48

Sefer: Daat Tevunot by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Sections:** §45-48
Shiur: Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's series on Daat Tevunot, Tuesday 29 November 2022

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Opening the third section

The first section dealt with the purpose of creation, the second with yihud Hashem and how fundamental it is to understanding the world and our purpose. So far the Ramhal has explained yihud Hashem only broadly. Now he will go into detail: the period of hester, when the unity is concealed, the period of gilui hayihud, when it is revealed in the days of Mashiah and olam haba, and how we move from one to the other.

Before that, he gives an introduction. Everything we say about God is never about His mahut, His essence. That is impossible and forbidden to discuss, which is what the Hakhamim meant by things one may not delve into. A finite mind with boundaries can never grasp something without boundaries. The principle: whatever your imagination can think of, that is not Hashem. When we speak of God, we speak only of how He relates to us.

His attributes are created (§45-46)

The Ramhal sums up: the Master is entirely negated of everything we find in His creatures, whether perfection or imperfection. Even "perfection" is not a trait in Him; it is the perfection of simplicity, one unity. His essence is completely incomprehensible, and nothing we see in our own lives applies to it.

But because He wanted to create beings, guide them, do good to them and let them enjoy His revelation and cleave to Him, He gave us ways in which He conducts Himself. The key word is that He created these attributes. When Kabbalah speaks of the ten sefirot, Keter, Hokhmah, Binah and the rest, it is not, God forbid, speaking of God Himself. They are lights and modes of conduct that Hashem created so that we can understand the world. They are attributable to Him, in that He truly acts in mercy and compassion, but He willed them, and He can change them at any moment.

The Rabbi repeated an image he has used before: the ten sefirot are one light of Hashem seen through different sunglasses. Wear brown glasses and you see brown light; wear green and you see green. The light is the same, filtered through different vessels, and all the filters are His creations. The same applies to the halal hapanui: the light He placed in the empty space, which we call the universe, is something He created by His will, not Hashem Himself, and the whole system can be overridden at any time.

Questions from the group

- **The Torah's descriptions of God:** all bodily language in the Torah is metaphorical, and more than that: "the hand of Hashem" does not even mean His own energy acting directly, but something that emanates from Him.
- **Why the Rambam is so strict:** one of the thirteen principles is that whoever believes God has a body is a heretic. People ask: what if someone read "Hashem stretched out His hand over Egypt" and simply took it literally? The Rambam still counts him a heretic, because he did not bother to study and understand what the Masui Rishon, the First Being, is, which is what we are doing here. A participant suggested this is why people find atheism or idolatry easier: believing in God properly requires bending your mind.

God's authority is total

In conclusion, the Ramhal says, His authority is complete, with nothing at all holding Him back. Even when we say God is angry on this day and pleased on that, or that Yom Kippur is a day of forgiveness, these are things He created, and they can be overridden at any time.

His essence will never be known, but we can understand a little of how He operates through the hanhagot and middot He created. The Rabbi's analogy: you might understand Elon Musk's business plans and what he is trying to do with Twitter, but you will not know who he is as a person until you have met him and had dinner with him. We can understand something of God's "plans," His hanhagot, middot and sefirot, but not God Himself.

Even His actions are known only by their results

A final point of the introduction: even His actions we know only as they appear to us, not how they are done. It looks to us as if God acts with compassion, but how that happens we cannot grasp. The Ramhal lists knowledge, memory, thought, compassion, anger and will. We do not say that because God is described this way, He knows, remembers or wills the way we do, with brains wired like ours. Only the end product looks like ours.

The Rabbi's example: in the Ohel Moed, the voice would come from the Ark and Moshe would hear it, but no one else would. Two things are at work. First, when we say God spoke, it is not God Himself speaking but a hashpaah, an influence of speech He created. Second, even that speech does not work like ours; it is a different kind of speech, which is why only Moshe could hear it. Likewise "Hashem remembered Sarah": not His essence remembering, but the hanhagah in charge of Sarah; and not remembering as we do, by jolting our memory. Only the result, that God remembered Sarah, is like ours.

A participant noted that the Torah does say how He acts: if you do this, I will give you that. The Rabbi answered that those are the rules of the system He created, like a programmer who sets up a computer so that pressing one button produces a result. It is the computer, the hanhagah, that does it. "We can never, ever talk about HaKadosh Barukh Hu itself."

The soul is ready (§47)

The Neshamah says these words have settled with it. But it cannot keep quiet when it looks at all the circumstances of the world under such an exalted Creator, bound by no limitation, and

without an explanation it will not understand. That ends the introduction to the third section.

The period of concealment (§48)

The Sekhel begins with the first period: the time when His unity is hidden, "kayom hazeh," as we see around us. This is also the time of service, since free choice exists only while yihud Hashem is concealed. (In the days of Mashiah, the Rabbi added, the choice is only between good and better, and only for a limited time.)

From His perfection, God could have made all His works perfect. But because He wanted to act in the way explained in the first two sections, He created "seder hadash mamash," an entirely new order, suited not to His perfection but to what His creatures need. In this new system good and bad are equally balanced. We have the same opportunity to do good as to do bad; it is a tug of war. Sometimes we do good and sometimes bad. Permission is given for temptation and for all kinds of corruption, including idolatry and every other evil, which the prophets say will one day be removed: "I will remove the spirit of impurity from the land," and death will be swallowed up forever.

Everything is in God's hands except our choice between good and bad. Nothing stops you from being as bad or as good as you want. This is why there is so much bad in the world, and why even the righteous suffer so much: there is so much evil and temptation, and much is expected of us. The Rabbi remarked that there is nothing new here, but the Ramhal is setting up the new period, to be continued on Thursday.

Summary

- The third section will detail the periods of concealment and revelation of God's unity and how one leads to the other.
- First, a warning: we never speak of God's essence; "whatever you can think of is not Hashem."
- The sefirot and attributes are lights and modes of conduct God created, like one light through different filters, and He can override them.
- Even His actions are known only by their results: His "speech" and "memory" do not work like ours.
- In the period of concealment God set up a new order in which good and evil are balanced, so that we can choose.

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